

BAHUJAN PITCH Rahul Gandhi speaks at Kanshi Ram's birth anniversary event in Lucknow, Mar. 13

ANI

sus as a means to secure representation for these communities in institutions and the corporate sector.

Two days later, Rahul upped the pitch by writing to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, urging that Kanshi Ram be awarded the Bharat Ratna. The letter, timed with the BSP founder's birth anniversary, said the award would be long overdue recognition matching Kanshi's impact on India's democratic landscape. Dalit thinkers and activists have been raising the demand for years, he pointed out.

The Congress was not alone. The Samajwadi Party, too, organised programmes across the state on Kanshi Ram's anniversary, invoking his ideas of social justice. Party chief Akhilesh Yadav harked back to a phase in UP politics when Kanshi Ram and Mulayam Singh Yadav had joined hands. "You might remember that, at one point, they together fought the BJP and defeated it. Only after that did the BJP start bringing Babasaheb Ambedkar's portraits to every event. His followers want that he be accorded due respect with the Bharat Ratna. We are saying the same," Akhilesh told the media.

Takeaways

- **Rahul Gandhi pitches for a Bharat Ratna to Kanshi Ram**
- **SP echoes the demand, recalls old Mulayam-era link**
- **With BSP's sway weakened, all are eyeing 21% Dalit vote**

SUITORS FOR DALIT VOTE

The timing is not coincidental. The bipartisan outreach comes at a time when the BSP's organisational and electoral grip appears diminished. As the 2024 general election indicated, the Dalit vote, roughly 21.1 per cent of UP's electorate, is increasingly open to persuasion. Coalescing it is a need, for the vote is internally divided across communities such as the Jatavs (around 11.7 per cent, once the BSP's core vote), Pasis (3.3 per cent), Valmikis (3.15 per cent), and numerous groups that add up to 66. It's natural, then, that Kanshi Ram matters. ■

TELANGANA

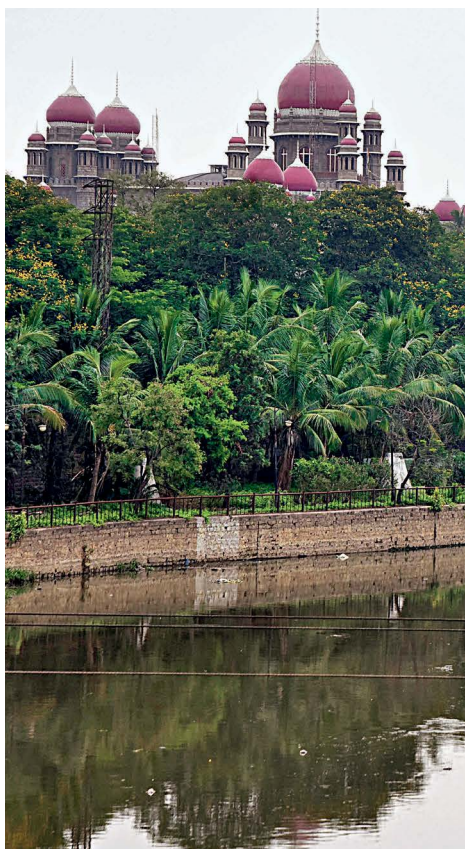
A RIVER RE

Revanth wants to adorn Hydera

By **Prasad Nichenametla**

A CITY ON A RIVER: that's not the image Hyderabad conjures up. Yet, that's how the city of Charminar was born, and reborn—and perhaps will be again, soon, if the latest bid to create a pleasing riverfront surmounts the series of unpleasant challenges it faces.

Government after government has attempted to give a facelift to the Musi, which flows 55 km through the Telangana capital. All have floundered in the face of the complexity of the task. Revanth



MOHAMMED ALEEMUDDIN